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Baba of Karo, a woman of the Muslim Hausa

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CHAPTER V c. 1904-1907 A GIRL'S FIRST MARRIAGE ()

*Bring the bridegroom's water,
Bring water with a threepence,
Bring the younger sister's water,
Bring water with a threepence.
One always gives water.
We'll drink from the stream,
We'll drink from the river—
Bring the bridegroom's water,
Bring water with a threepence!*

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Then the groom's younger sister, the bride's new joking relation, comes quickly with a vessel of water with a threepenny piece in it, she puts it down at the door of the hut and runs away. They try to catch her and pour the water over her. If she is slow and doesn't come at once, then the bride and her friends rush off and run away towards the river, while the older people chase them to get her back. Some brides run right away and go home, then the bridegroom's chief friend has to go after her—he always brings her back, because he is stronger than she is. The bride's friends and the groom's younger sisters are playing and teasing, the friends won't let the bridegroom's younger sisters enter the bride's hut, and when food is being eaten, if the younger sisters come near, the bride's friends will smear them with porridge and stew and oil and they will have to run away and wash. If the bridegroom's younger brothers come in, they get into trouble too. Meanwhile the bride's grandmothers are busy washing her again behind her hut—quietly this time, with no drumming—and then they clothe her in her best things and put on her ornaments, and take her back into her hut. The chief  95 *kawa* steals the bride's slippers and hides them, and her *mawankiya* has to pay her to bring them back. Then the

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kawa sweeps out the bride's hut, she puts the sweepings into a beautiful bowl and takes it, covered up, to the bridegroom; she says he is to buy the bowl. If he refuses she pours the sweepings all over him; if he pays then she takes the money and leaves him. They all run away—the bride's *kawa* and her younger sisters and all the girls. Meanwhile the older women are preparing the food and getting the bride's hut ready.

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